to some carefully-calibrated nuclear sabre-rattling during this period. Musharraf said on 5 June that he would not renounce Pakistan's right to use nuclear weapons first, in response to our external affairs minister saying that India would not be the first to use nuclear weapons. We military leaders or other decision-makers sometimes overlook the fact that whatever happens in a volatile region such as ours would have a great impact on the rest of the world. This is more so because of the nuclear dimension. That it is not just going to be an India-Pakistan affair, as was the case in 1965 or 1971, is something we must always bear in mind. How successful the military build-up against Pakistan proved to be is debatable, but eventually a military conflict did not take place. The thrust of the government's strategy was on 'coercive diplomacy.' Pakistan was put under tremendous pressure during this stand-off. But after a certain stage, I was not sure whether the operation was serving any purpose, or had became an exercise in futility. Waiting endlessly for months out in the open sapped the energy of even the fittest and most motivated troops. Was this the best way to achieve our aims? My response is, perhaps not. Did we have an exit strategy? To the best of my knowledge, the answer is no. Perhaps this reflects a lack of clarity or fuzziness about our overall national strategy at that time.

On the other hand, there were many plus points of this operation too. There was some clamping down of terrorist infrastructure in Pakistan and reduction in terrorist activities in Kashmir, the results of which we got to see in 2004 and thereafter. We got to know our operational areas thoroughly and refined our plans, the relationship between the leader and the led got cemented, and we made up our equipment deficiencies to a large extent. A peace dialogue between India and Pakistan was initiated, and a ceasefire along the LoC was agreed to in 2003 by both sides, which is still holding. Finally, Operation Parakaram was called off in October 2002 and we returned to Mathura.

The sad part of the previous two years was that most of us in 1 Corps spent about a year and a quarter living like gypsies under canvas or in caravans. I did not even get to see the face of Mathura